

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 154

Culture (OWC): [Ovimbundu \(FP13\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1929-1930

Coverage Date: 1929

Place Coverage: Angola

Section Title(S): DOMESTIC ANIMALS

Bulls are castrated when two years old. The wound is rubbed with ashes, salt, soot, and palm oil. Bullocks are used for riding, also for pull-carts introduced by the Boers. The herd obtains most of its food by grazing. In the dry season grass withers, with the result that the animals become thin and stall-feeding is necessary. In former days cattle-raiding was a practice of the Ovimbundu, who robbed the Vacilenge. It is certain that the Ovimbundu did not own cattle when they entered Angola. If the general tradition is correct the Ovimbundu came into Angola from a northeasterly direction, from the borders of the Belgian Congo as it is called today; this is not a cattle-raising region.

174
[Historical
 Reconstruction](#)

232
[Applied Animal
 Science](#)

233
[Pastoral Activities](#)

492
[Animal Transport](#)

The Ovimbundu of Elende have a joke against the people of Bailundu, because the latter on first seeing a cow offered the animal some food on a wooden platter. This story suggests that the Bailundu people, who are of the Ovimbundu confederacy, did not know the animal and its habits as early as did the Ovimbundu themselves.

174
[Historical
 Reconstruction](#)

233
[Pastoral Activities](#)

Although the Ovimbundu do not usually kill their cattle they may do so in the months of June and July, because at this time pasture is withered and food is scarce. Animals which are diseased, aged, or injured, are killed and eaten.

233
[Pastoral Activities](#)

The native pig is distinguishable from European breeds by its long thin snout and slender development. This breed is said by the Director of Animal Husbandry, Humpata, to be the Keltic breed (Plate LV). There is, he says, no evidence to prove that the Ovimbundu have at any time domesticated pigs from the wild hogs which are to be found in Angola. There is no family which does not own a pig, and on the whole the pig fares much better than the sheep or the goat. The pig receives water and a daily ration of food, which is usually sweet potatoes and their leaves, together with some corn. Male pigs are castrated at any time between the ages of six months and one year by an operator who is a paid specialist. The fee for castrating a bull is four yards of cloth, but a small gift is considered sufficient reward for performing the operation on a pig. If a pig is thin, the leather is said to be of good quality and therefore suitable for making sheaths for knives. Usually the flesh of the pig is eaten shortly after the animal has been killed, but the meat of the bullock, on the contrary, is sometimes dried over a fire and preserved. But this is not a general practice as the animals are too valuable to be slaughtered.

176

Innovation

231

Domesticated Animals

232

Applied Animal
Science

252

Food Preparation

282

Leather Industry

463

Occupational
Specialization

Human Relations Area Files

*755 Prospect Street**New Haven, CT 06511*General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.eduIssues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)